

Atypical Anorexia Nervosa

What is Atypical Anorexia Nervosa?

Atypical Anorexia Nervosa (Atypical AN) is a serious and potentially life-threatening mental health condition. The main symptoms include:

- Eating much less food than the body needs for energy
- Feeling really anxious about gaining weight
- Negative body image
- Defining your self-worth mainly in terms of weight or shape

Is it different from Anorexia Nervosa (AN)?

People with Atypical AN experience the same symptoms as those with AN. The difference is that a person with Atypical AN is not technically underweight despite eating very restrictively (and losing weight). This can be the most distressing aspect of Atypical AN, as the eating disorder is often “hidden in plain sight”.

Atypical AN **does not mean** a person has ‘failed’ at having an eating disorder, is not ‘sick enough’, or their experience isn’t valid or real. Research has shown that **Atypical AN is just as serious as AN**. People with Atypical AN can have the same serious physical and mental health problems (as below), and may require admission to hospital because of their symptoms.

Consequences of Atypical AN

Starvation Syndrome: People with Atypical AN can experience starvation syndrome, which refers to the harmful effects of eating too little for a long period of time. Starvation syndrome affects a person’s physical health, how they think, behave and feel. Starvation Syndrome can occur at any weight and not just in those who are underweight. See our handout on [Starvation Syndrome](#) for more information.

Physical health problems: People with Atypical-AN can experience low heart rate, amenorrhea (loss of periods), gastrointestinal issues, fatigue, and muscle damage. The only health complication of Atypical AN that has been shown to be less severe than AN is the effect on bone mineral density.

Negative thoughts and emotions: People with Atypical AN can often hyper-focus on body weight, size, and shape. They may have low self-worth, low self-esteem, and difficulty thinking and concentrating. They can experience irritability, mood swings, and symptoms of anxiety and depression.

Stigma: People experiencing Atypical AN are at risk of not being taken seriously, their physical or emotional

suffering being dismissed or given unhelpful advice, like being told to diet or lose weight.

Reduced quality of life: Atypical AN affects many areas of a person’s daily life including social situations, work, relationships, and overall enjoyment of life.

Seeking Help and Treatment

People with Atypical AN require the same physical renourishment and psychological therapy as those with AN to support their recovery.

Regardless of not having a technically low body weight, a key part of treatment involves restoring or normalising weight to within a range that’s natural for the person’s body and not managed through eating disorder behaviours. This is vital to reverse medical complications, and help the brain and body to recover and function optimally. Studies have found that weight and nutritional restoration are the most important factors in preventing a relapse.

It is important to have regular appointments for medical monitoring with a General Practitioner (GP), and it can be helpful to have nutritional support from a dietitian who understands and supports the seriousness of Atypical AN.

Psychological treatment for Atypical AN can involve **Cognitive Behavioural Therapy for Eating Disorders (CBT-ED)** for adults, or **Family Based Treatment for Anorexia (FBT)** for young people.

Many people with Atypical AN use their eating disorder as a way to cope with distress, trauma, and fears.

Treatment can focus on:

- Identifying and challenging fears
- Learning new strategies to manage mood, distress, or trauma without using eating disorder behaviours.
- Explore body acceptance.
- Find self-worth and value outside of weight or shape
- Increase flexibility with eating and exercise

Recovery

Although challenging, **a full recovery is completely possible and worth it**. The recovery process allows people the opportunity to improve their overall health and wellbeing, quality of life, and reduce risk of chronic illness.

If you or someone close to you has signs of an eating disorder, it is important to see your GP and discuss seeking help as soon as possible.